

Pack Actions, however, can cross the Gauntlet although this has its limitations (see below). Only the attacking creature and the target of the attack must be valid targets.

At times, creatures involved in a combat will end up on different sides of the Gauntlet, for instance from the use of pack actions or because a creature played an Umbral Escape. In these cases, several rules apply:

- A creature may only play a Combat Action during a round of combat if it has a valid target, or it plays a non-damaging combat action. The target of a Combat Action must be valid both when targets are declared and when the Combat Action is due to land, otherwise it is discarded for no effect. A valid target is one in the same world or one that the creature is able to attack across the Gauntlet.
- If a creature had no valid targets this round and does not have any valid targets during the Withdrawal step, remove it from the combat.

INTERACTION ACROSS THE GAUNTLET

Some cards will allow creatures to interact with things across the Gauntlet. For instance, if a creature equipped with an *Incarna Sigil* (and in the physical world) played *Strange Rain*, it would affect all creatures, not just those in the physical world. Cards played across the Gauntlet can be cancelled from either world.

Targets attacked in the Umbra from the physical world (for instance, by someone using an *Incarna Sigil*) may fight back as normal: their Combat Actions can target the attacking creature, and Gifts played by the targeted creature affect and can target the attacking creature. Note that both sides can use pack actions normally, although this does not grant any ability to play cards across the Gauntlet to creatures joining the pack combat.

CHAPTER 6: COMBAT

Definition: Opponent

A creature one (or more) of your pack are in combat against. An ability which only targets or affects “opponents” can normally only be used in combat.

Definition: Attack

1. The instigation of combat between the attacking creature and its target (e.g. *King Albrecht* attacks *Zhyzhak*).
2. A Combat Action which has a damage value (e.g. *Dis-Arm*, *Dry Gulch*).

Definition: Challenge

A request to enter combat with a member of another pack not eligible to be attacked (i.e. not an Alpha). May be refused. If accepted, it becomes an attack. You may only challenge creatures. You can not challenge Territories or Battlefields.

Definition: Attacker

In a combat, the creature who made the attack or a creature in pack combat with another attacker.

Definition: Defender

In a combat, any creatures fighting against the attacker(s).

Definition: Escape

Leave combat (it doesn't return without a card effect). If a creature escapes, only that creature leaves combat - it has no effect on other participants. If a creature leaves combat but will return (e.g. *Nerve Agent*), it does not imply that it escaped.

6.1 COMBAT DECLARATION

Combat begins when an alpha declares an attack against another alpha, an Enemy or a Victim. It can also begin after an alpha attacks a Territory or challenges a non-alpha pack member. Certain sept cards can also initiate combat (e.g. *Sneak Attack*). In no circumstances can a pack member attack a member of its own pack. A creature in the Hunting Grounds can not attack another creature in the hunting grounds.

General combat timing:

- In each step of combat except the Declaration step, and where cards and abilities are playable, first the attacker, then the defender, then other players have an opportunity to play cards and use abilities.
- The cycle repeats until all players pass in sequence, then the combat moves to the next step.
- Where multiple other players wish to play, decide the order randomly.

1. Declaration Step: Closed Play.

- Declare attacker and (intended) target.
- Attacker uses abilities or cards played during the attack declaration (including certain Combat Events such as *Hunting Party*).
- Defending player, if any, uses abilities or cards played during the attack declaration (*Shieldmate* is the only card at present).

2. Pre-Combat step Closed Play. Each player may play cards which change the participants in the combat.

- This includes announcing Pack actions, defense of Territories, redirecting the attack, stepping in for Prey, defending a Battlefield, combat cancelling, etc. This step continues until no players wish to use any more cards or abilities at this step.
- Changing the target of the attack has no effect on pack attacks already in effect.
- Changing the target of the attack does not cancel pack defences already played. If the target is changed to a creature not participating in the pack defence, all members of the pack defence are removed from combat; however cards drawn for the pack defence remain in the player's combat hand until played or discarded normally (e.g. at the end of combat).
- Cards and abilities which create pack attacks or defences can be used later, in the beginning- of-combat step or between- rounds step, except where restricted on the card.

3. Beginning-of-Combat step: Open Play.

- Each player may play relevant Open Play cards and abilities.
- This includes other before-combat events (such as a beginning-of-combat *Frenzy*), Gifts to heighten the combat (*Spirit of the Fray*, for instance), and so forth.

Sidebar: Combat Events

A quick reminder: all Combat Events are Combat Restricted. Combat Events stay in play until their effect ends.

6.2 COMBAT ROUNDS

Combat is divided into combat rounds, during which each player involved in the combat plays a Combat Action for their creature(s). The cards are simultaneously revealed, and most will do a certain amount of damage to the opponent. If a Combat Action causes damage to an opponent, place that Combat Action under the affected creature as a damage card. If a creature has damage greater than or equal to its health, it dies (see damage and Death). Steps 1-6 of the combat round are Closed Play.

The rigorous timing of combat rounds is:

1. Play Card step Each creature in combat may play a combat card face down.

- Players declare if creatures are using any weapons at this point; if nothing is said, it is assumed that creatures will use any weapons they are carrying.
- Players do not have to play combat cards for all (or any of) their creatures in combat unless affected by Forced Play

2. Targeting Step Targets of combat cards are declared.

- Targets can be assigned to all combat cards, even if they need no target.
- Targets must both be in the same world (see rules on Umbral combat).

3. Reveal Step All face down combat cards are revealed.

- Creatures that are Feinting may play a card
- Instinctive cards can be played.

4. Bluff Step determine if cards will be discarded or will resolve in next step

- Discard all illegal cards.
- Check for whether bluffs succeed or fail and discard failures
- At the end of this step, the only combat cards left on the table should be ones that will be resolved in Resolution

5. Resolution Step

1. Fast Striking Actions resolve. Creatures removed from combat (e.g. killed) discard any unresolved Combat Actions they were playing.
2. Normal actions resolve. Creatures removed from combat (e.g. killed) discard any unresolved Combat Actions they were playing.
3. Slow Striking Actions resolve.
 - Cards which redirect or prevent damage are used when the damage would hit. Cards which heal damage cannot be used here.
 - Where a creature takes damage at the same speed, the opponent decides which order the damage lands.

- Non-frenzied creatures killed in combat are immediately removed from combat and sent to the appropriate Victory Pile or discard pile.

6. Withdrawal Step: The attacker may announce a withdrawal, unless a creature is frenzied.

- Any effects which take effect (or end) "at the end of the round" happen (or end) now, before withdrawal.
- If the attacker announces a withdrawal, combat ends. If not, combat continues to the Between-rounds step.

7. Between-rounds step: Open Play.

- Each player may play relevant Open Play cards and abilities.
- After this step, start a new combat round at step 1.

6.3 ENDING COMBAT

Combat ends when:

- no creature played a Combat Action during the current combat round;
- there are no attackers or no defenders in the combat;
- the attacker withdraws from combat;
- or a card that forces combat to end is played.
- If one full round of combat passes where a creature has no valid targets, it is removed from the combat. See also Umbral Combat

After every combat, all players refill their combat hand back up to their combat hand size (but cannot voluntarily discard any cards before doing so). If a player runs out of combat cards in his combat deck, he immediately reshuffles his discarded combat cards and may continue drawing from the deck.

6.3.1 WITHDRAWING

An attacker in combat may break off the attack (end combat) during the Withdrawal step of any combat round (including during the first round of combat). Withdrawing is not an action. Withdrawing ends the whole combat, and abilities which force or prevent withdrawal affect all attackers (e.g. *Maim* will prevent any attacker withdrawing, no matter how many attackers there are). It is not possible to withdraw in this fashion while any creature is in full frenzy. A defender cannot withdraw.

6.4 DAMAGE AND DEATH

Whenever a card - Combat Action or otherwise - damages a creature, it becomes a damage card on that creature. Damage cards are placed under the creature so that the bottom of the card is showing. If the damage value of a damage card is increased or decreased from its printed value, it should be marked in some way. Each damage card on a creature takes it closer to death. When the damage on a creature equals or exceeds its health*, it dies. No amount of healing will bring the creature back at that point.

* Characters in breed form do not die at this point if they have a crinos form they can flip to. If a Character in Breed form takes damage and its total damage is equal to or greater than its printed Rage or its printed Health, it flips to its crinos/battle form (unless prevented from doing so). It only dies if its damage equal or exceeds its crinos-form Health.

If a Character is forced into breed form, and has suffered more damage than his breed form health, he is dead. If a Character is forced to change forms, he can use a card that allows him to change back in order to cancel the change (e.g. *Shapeshift*, *Fang Necklace of Fenris*): this acts as a cancellation of the effect. This does not include abilities which do not explicitly state on the card that you may change forms.

6.4.1 HEALING DAMAGE

Definition: Aggravated damage- Aggravated damage is damage that cannot be regenerated, although it can be removed and healed. Aggravated damage cards should be marked in some way.

Most Characters regenerate their damage card with the lowest damage during the Regeneration phase, but other cards can heal or remove damage. When a damage card is healed, all ongoing effects caused by the damage end (e.g. *Head Wound*, *Maim*). However, effects which have already taken place are not reversed (e.g. destroyed equipment), nor are effects cancelled if they are not caused by the damage (e.g. *Hamstringed*, *Body Wrack*). Once a card resolves and becomes a damage card, it no longer counts as its original card type and cannot be cancelled.

6.4.2 Death

Whenever a creature dies and is not in Full Frenzy:

- Discard all cards except Past Lives that are attached to dead creatures
- Take Past Lives and put them in the dead character's owner's Victory Pile
- Discard any Gifts or Rites with ongoing effects that only affect the deceased. Other ongoing and permanent effects played by the deceased remain in play.

- Creatures killed in combat are placed in the Victory Pile of the player that killed them. If they were killed by Prey, treat them as if they were died outside combat

6.4.3 VP COMPLICATIONS

Normally you earn VP equal to the renown of the creatures you kill. However, Wyrms normally gain 0 VP for killing Enemies. Gaia creatures normally gain 0 VP for killing Victims. They WILL earn full VP if the Prey initiated the attack against them. Effects which grant bonus VP to a kill (or reduce its VP) occur AFTER you determine whether you received VP equal to the renown of the creature or not.

If you killed a creature but it was worth no Victory Points for some reason, it is still placed in your Victory Pile. Some effects can also modify the value of kills in your Victory Pile. If a separate card is not placed in the card to show you how the value is modified, mark the modified card in some way to remind you how it was modified. See sidebar on suggestions of how to mark this.

When determining who killed an creature, there can not be more than one killer. Whoever dealt the damage that killed it is the killer. (see Resolution Step) You can also have circumstances where a creature died in combat but no creature directly killed it.

If a creature dies while fighting against your pack, gain VP as if your pack killed it. However only if one creature kills another by dealing it damage (as opposed to reducing its health or other means) does it count as a kill for that creature. Example: If Scar Throat Leech-Killer is fighting a vampire and something is played that reduces the vampires health so it is now dead, Scar Throat does NOT gain bonus victory points for the vampire because he did not kill it.

6.4.4 DEATH OUTSIDE COMBAT

If a creature dies outside combat, it is not worth Victory Points unless a card effects says otherwise. Characters killed in this way are removed from the game. Other creatures are simply discarded to their owner's sept discard pile.

6.5 COMBAT DECLARATION OPTIONS

A member of a pack may NEVER declare an attack or challenge against another member of his own pack, regardless of any card text. Nor may Prey attack other Prey. Similarly, a player may NEVER play combat cards for creatures on both sides of a combat.

6.5.1 ATTACKING A CREATURE

Combat will begin between the attacker and defender. Use the combat declaration sequence. An attack cannot be declared except as an Alpha action or with a card ability. An attack can only be declared against valid targets: for alpha actions, that is (normally) another alpha or Prey; valid targets for other attacks are determined by the card ability; a target becomes invalid if it cannot be attacked across the Gauntlet or if the attacker is prevented from attacking it by some other effect (e.g. it is forced to attack something else).

6.5.2 CHALLENGING

An alpha may challenge a member of another pack who is not their alpha. This is counted as an attack except that creature can normally decline the challenge (in the defender section of the Declaration step). If the challenge is declined there is no combat and the challenger's alpha action is over.

6.5.3 ATTACKING A BATTLEFIELD

Battlefields can normally only be attacked as an Alpha action.

6.5.3.A ATTACKING A BATTLEFIELD

Battlefields can be attacked from either side of the Gauntlet but are assumed to exist only on the side they are attacked from for the duration of the combat. When a Battlefield is attacked, it can be defended by another alpha or, if none is eligible or volunteers, it will defend itself.

Defense by an alpha. Any Alpha that matches the Defender conditions may defend. This is considered a type of stepping in. It may defend with a total renown of pack members, including the Alpha, up to the Defender Renown. This counts as a pack defense.

Self-defending. If no alpha defends the Battlefield, a single player will play for the Battlefield.

Sidebar: marking VP modification

Face up cards are always assumed to be unmodified. Face down cards are always 1 VP. Face up cards, turned sideways in your pile are worth 0 VP.

If you need to mark a modification other than 1VP or 0VP, you may use whatever method works for you to remember it. Use tokens, write down the modifications, flip the orientation, etc. Just be consistent and be prepared to answer questions from your opponent as to what your current Victory Point total is.

- The Battlefield will have Rage, Gnosis and Health equal to its Renown.
- The Battlefield automatically has the Keywords listed for the Defending Alpha (choose one if there are options).
- The defending player may also choose ONE additional creature Keyword to give the Battlefield. Examples of Keywords: Black Fury, Ahroun, Spirit, Kailindo (but not Fast or Slow Striking).
- Selecting the Spirit keyword allows the Battlefield to exist on both sides of the Gauntlet.

6.5.3.B BATTLEFIELD COMBAT

Once defenders have been chosen, both sides draw the number of additional combat cards listed against the chosen attacker/chosen defender and follow any special rules listed for attacker and defender. You cannot use additional cards to draw in more renown of creatures or draw additional cards, unless they specifically mention Battlefields.

- Combat Events can be used as normal, but they will not add creatures or draw additional cards unless they specify they work on the Battlefield. Their other effects will still take place. Example: if you play Frenzy, the frenzied creature still fights until “hacked apart” but draws no cards for the frenzy.
- Any cards that refer to “yielding a Battlefield” means the attacker is withdrawing, as per normal Withdrawal rules.

6.5.4C VICTORY POINTS

- **Self-defending:** If you defeat the Battlefield put it in your Victory Pile where it is worth VP equal to its Renown. If you do not defeat the Battlefield, any damage on it is healed at the end of combat.
- **Defense by an alpha:** Normally you only score VP for the creatures you kill in this combat except...
- **Defense by an alpha, where one side sweeps the battlefield:** that side puts the Battlefield in their Victory Pile where it is worth VP equal to its Renown. You sweep the Battlefield if, at the end of the round, you still have creatures on the Battlefield but your opponent does not. This includes if the attacker Yields the Battlefield or withdraws

6.5.4 ATTACKING A TERRITORY

Use the combat declaration sequence normally: combat will result if a pack member defends their territory.

If an alpha chooses to attack another pack's Territory, that pack's alpha may choose to defend the Territory. **Defending** a Territory is an action. Either side may use pack tactics.

If the attacker kills the defender, or all defenders leave combat before the attackers, the Territory is destroyed and discarded. A Territory is likewise destroyed if the pack controlling it does not choose to defend it or cannot do so (e.g. they have no alpha). If the combat is ended prematurely, or the attacker withdraws, the Territory is not destroyed.

Territories exist in both worlds. If your alpha is in the Umbra and attacks a territory whose alpha is in the physical world, the opposing alpha cannot defend the territory, and the territory is destroyed. (and vice versa) See Umbral combat.

6.5.5 ATTACKING TO BIND

When you attack a Spirit in the Hunting Grounds, if the attacker is in the Umbra, you may announce that you are attempting to bind it instead. If you kill the Spirit while it is in this combat, instead heal all damage on it, including any damage that was on it from previous combats, and it becomes an Ally of your pack. While it remains an Ally of your pack, the bound Spirit is worth half its Renown (round up) in VP. The bound Spirit is worth VP as normal if it is killed by an opponent. Players only get victory points for binding Spirits if they bind them as a result of attacking them to bind.

Binding a spirit does not actually kill the spirit and no effect that is triggered by killing a creature will be triggered by binding a spirit.

If you attempted to bind a spirit and did not do enough damage to “kill” it, the damage remains on it after combat ends.

Wyrms creatures can get VP for binding Spirit Enemies. Gaia creatures can get VP for binding Spirit Victims.

6.5.6 FORCED ATTACKS

In some cases, an effect will force an attacker to declare an attack against a particular target. The attacker may not be forced to attack a non-valid target (see Attacking a creature). If the attacker is forced to attack multiple targets, he may select which of the targets to attack (alphas do not get multiple alpha actions to attack each one). In most cases, alphas can choose to pass or take an alternate Alpha action that does not involve attacking rather than make a forced attack.

If an ability prevents an otherwise forced attack (e.g. that alpha you have a rivalry with has a *Flower of Aphrodite*), the creature is no longer forced to attack that target as it is not a valid target. (see attacking a creature)

See also Rivalry and Can't vs Must effects

6.5.7 ATTACK RESTRICTIONS

Various card effects and rules effects (such as Loyalty) can prevent you attacking a specific creature or other target. When the attacker can't attack a target, it means:

- They cannot declare attacks against the target.
- They cannot voluntarily join a pack attack against the target (but will do so if the effect is "automatic" or brings in your whole pack).

It has no effect on playing Combat Actions or choosing targets for Combat Actions.

Challenging is a type of attack. You can not challenge things you can not attack.

6.5.8 PACK COMBAT

Cards and abilities which let you pack attack or defend can be played and used in the precombat step, beginning-of-combat step or a between-rounds step, except as limited by the card. (E.g. Cub's Cry can be used "between rounds of combat", i.e. only in a between-rounds step.) Notable exceptions Hunting Party, Attacking the Wyrms and Ass Whuppin' Lynch Mob which can only be played during the Declaration step.

Some creatures can automatically join pack combat or draw others into combat. An ability which says *this* creature can pack attack or defend with *that* creature means that, as per the circumstances on the card, *this* creature can join in pack attack or defence (e.g. Dreams-of-Wonder can join in pack attack or defence in any combat in which one of her Spirit Allies is already fighting). These abilities can be used even if *that* creature was brought into pack combat by some other means. E.g. if *Blood-on-the-Wind* pack attacks with *Allison Kachina* and *Dreams-of-Wonder*, *Allison* can bring her brother, and *Dreams* can bring in her Spirit buddies.

Creatures pack defending in the Hunting Ground works the same way.

You cannot bring creatures from outside your pack into pack combat nor pack defend with creatures in the Hunting Ground unless specifically stated on a card. Similarly, if a card does let you bring in creatures from outside your pack, you cannot bring in creatures such that a creature is in a pack with the target of its Rivalry. See also Pack Actions in Play-Cards Step Options

6.5.9 STEPPING IN

A Gaia Alpha may, at his option, step in place of a Victim when an attack has been declared against that Victim. Likewise, a Wyrms Alpha may step in and defend for an Enemy when an attack is declared against that Enemy. It is not considered the creature's Alpha action to "step in" in this manner but it is an action.

If two alphas want to step in and defend, the creature with the highest Renown gets to do so (decide ties randomly). See Umbral Combat for how that affects stepping in.

6.6 PLAY-CARD STEP OPTIONS

6.6.1 MULTIPLE CARDS

Sometimes a creature will be able to play multiple Combat Actions during a round. These are considered separate Combat Actions, and may be targeted at different opponents.

When one side has multiple combat cards played at the same time, the controlling player may determine the order that the blows land when they damage their targets. This is particularly important when the damage would kill a creature (due to death blow abilities such as *Taking the Death Blow* or the VP bonus of *Scar Throat Leech-Killer*). A creature is considered killed by the creature who played the fatal damage card.

6.6.2 PACK ACTIONS

Certain cards allow groups of creatures to enter combat as packs, much like normal wolves. A pack action is any combat in which you have more than one member of your pack in combat at the same time (or, if playing for prey, when prey pack defend). In a pack action, you have multiple creatures on your side of combat, and each is able to play Combat Actions. A pack defence is a pack combat for the defending side (creatures which automatically pack defend join the defender in a pack defence). A pack attack is a pack action for the attacking side (creatures which automatically pack attack join the attacker in a pack attack).

In pack combat, each creature in combat may play a combat action, although they do not need to do so (unless compelled to do so by forced play). The player must select which card is being played by whom (while they are face down).

6.6.3 PLAYING FOR PREY

Whenever a prey creature needs to play a Combat Action, a player not in combat against it plays for it from their combat hand. Only one player can play for prey each round, but which player that is can change between rounds. If the available players cannot agree between themselves, decide randomly between those that want to play for prey.

When an Enemy or Victim can play multiple Combat Actions (e.g. *Pentex Forestry Team*, *Zmei*), all combat actions it plays during a single combat round must come from the same player's hand. If prey is in a pack action, all the cards for creatures in the pack action must come from the same player.

6.6.4 UMBRA-ONLY COMBAT ACTIONS

Combat Actions which must be played in the Umbra require both the creature playing the card and the target (if any) to be in the Umbra. Spirits normally exist in both the real world and Umbra simultaneously, so may play Umbra-only combat actions against things in the Umbra or other spirits. See Umbral combat.

6.6.5 ALTERNATE COMBAT ACTIONS

Certain non-combat cards (i.e. sept cards) are played as combat actions, or played in place of combat actions. If you can play Multiple Combat Actions in a round, you may Alternate Combat actions for all or some of them, up to the total allowed.

- A card or ability that is played as a Combat Action (e.g. *Wasp Talons*, *Wanchese's Bow*) is considered a legal Combat Action. It can be dodged, or *Distracted*, and bluffs will not work against the user.
- Alternative Combat Actions are played at the end of the Reveal Step. Choose a target as they are played.
- All Alternative Combat Actions are considered Instinctive.

6.6.6 RESTRICTED, FORCED AND RANDOM PLAY

6.6.6A RESTRICTED PLAY

If a card restricts a creature to playing Combat Actions which meet certain Rage restrictions (e.g. *Catfeet*, *Drattosi*), any other Combat Action played by the creature is illegal. The restrictions are absolute: a creature that is restricted to Rage 1 Combat Actions cannot play Combat Actions without a Rage requirement (or rather, such cards are illegal).

Restricted Play does NOT require you play a card in a given round. It does mean if you play anything, it must meet the restriction (else be considered illegal).

If you have no cards you can play legally due to the requirements of Restricted Play, this does NOT count as being prevented from playing a combat action for abilities like Gloom-at-Midnight or for playing Instinctive Combat Actions.

6.6.6B FORCED PLAY

Forced play requires you to play a card every round you are forced to play, if you have **any** Combat cards available. (see also Can't vs. Must effects) This can force you to play an illegal card.

- You cannot play Alternate Combat Actions while affected by Forced Play effects.
- If you are part of a pack action, you may select cards for creatures unaffected by Forced Play effects first, then for all creatures affected by forced play. If multiple creatures are affected by forced play, you may have them play their forced cards in any order.
- You can be affected by multiple Forced Play and Restricted Play effects. If the revealed card does not meet ALL the conditions of the Forced Play and Restricted Play effects, it is illegal.

6.6.6C RANDOM PLAY

- Random play is a specific type of forced play. For each card a creature must play randomly, a random card is picked from the player's combat hand. Targets will be chosen as normal in next step.
- Random cards can be illegal cards (including Combat Events) and are handled normally in the Establish-bluff step.
- If a prey creature is made to play randomly, also decide randomly which player (excluding the opposing player) will play for all prey this round, even if that player has nothing the prey can legally play.

6.7 TARGETING STEP OPTIONS

Each combat card played in the previous step is assigned a target. Where one side has pack combat, the opponent of the pack